

HOW THE RACKET WAS RUN

THE DON'S CAPERS: For two decades, Dr Amit Kumar stayed ahead of the law. Whenever he got caught, he got bail, went underground and bribed his way to a new identity in another location, where the law left enough loopholes.

DEMAND AND SUPPLY

Seventy per cent of those who sold a kidney were poor labourers or street vendors who were lured by middlemen with promises of money and jobs. Most of the recipients were rich westerners who could cough up Rs 20 lakh for a kidney.

IMTIAZ KHAN



Wasim, a victim of Kumar's racket

MODUS OPERANDI

The Gurgaon gang consisted of over two dozen doctors, helpers and touts

Touts approached patients, who were visiting hospitals for dialysis, with transplant proposals

The donors were paid Rs 50,000-Rs 1 lakh. Organs were sold for 10 times as much.

In the last nine years, Kumar did over 500 transplants, making over Rs 1,000 crore



Dr Kumar (left) with brother Jeevan

The Gurgaon gang transplanted over 500 kidneys in the course of nine years

CASE HISTORY

When renal transplants became common in India in the '70s with anti-rejection drugs being introduced in the market, Kumar set up a fake Ayurvedic hospital to carry out a trade in human organs. In 1993, he masterminded the country's first major kidney racket in Mumbai.

Lack of surveillance and an atmosphere of loose medical ethics fuelled the growth of the transplant empire

HOW THE POLICE NABBED THEM

■ On January 22, a victim tipped off the police at Moradabad about the Gurgaon gang

■ Two touts, caught with money and syringes in their vehicle, spilled the beans on Kumar's network

■ On January 24, with constables as bait, police caught the chief accomplice, and raided Kumar's house in Palam Vihar

■ Kumar had fled. The basement of his house was full of surgical equipment and terrified 'donors'



POST DOC: Police inspecting equipment at Kumar's house

off, it was because he was confident that he could bribe his way out of any police trouble. The network he operated was hardly new. It was a more refined version of the model he had used in Mumbai decades back. His gang consisted of over two dozen doctors, helpers and touts. The latter would keep an eye on patients visiting various hospitals for dialysis and approach them with transplant proposals (Irshad Gyassuddin, one of his touts, told the police that his network of 30

men alone had found over 250 donors for Kumar since 2006). The donors were given anything between Rs 50,000 and Rs 1 lakh for their organs, which were then sold for 10 times as much to rich Indians and westerners. In the past nine years, Kumar had done over 500 transplants. It is no wonder then that he is believed to be worth Rs 1,000 crore or more.

Kumar, though, hadn't reckoned with the gutsy and tenacious Manzil Saini, additional superintendent of po-

lice, Moradabad. Two days earlier, the Glock pistol-packing Saini had listened attentively to a complainant brought in by her constable, who said he had been duped into parting with one of his kidneys by a tout. Saini immediately put a team together to pursue the tip-off. The police caught up with two touts, at large in the 'labour chowk' of the town and luring *pappus* with promising job offers in Gurgaon. "We found money and syringes they used for matching blood samples in their vehicle," says Saini. A dose of tough grilling and they blurted out vital clues about a thriving network run by Kumar in and around Gurgaon. The police then raided the place and

ey transplants in the country are illegal